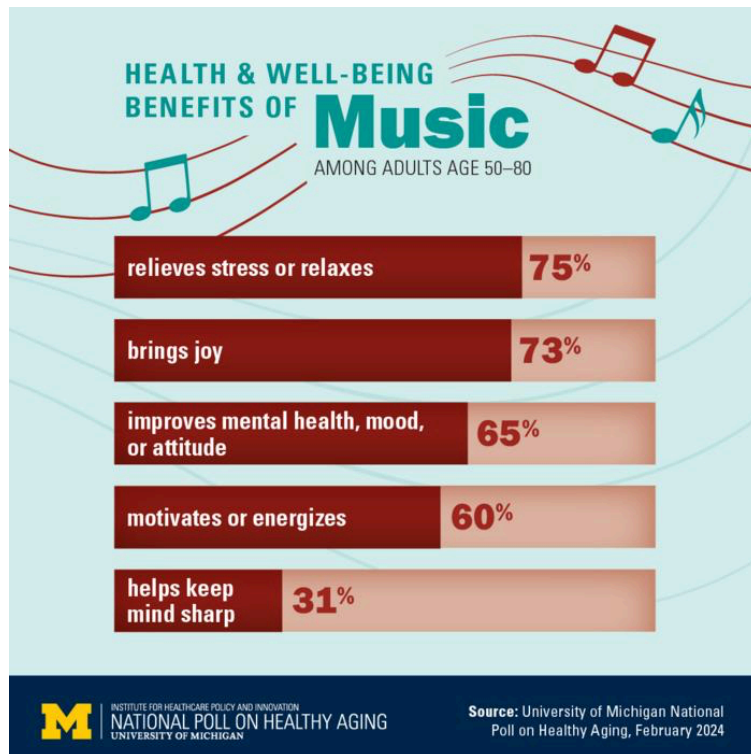


THE IMPORTANCE OF MUSIC FOR COGNITIVE HEALTH

For seniors, music is often more than simply sound or entertainment. It can function as therapy to reduce anxiety, manage agitation, and build social connection. Moreover, studies have shown improvements in seniors' mood, memory, sleep and physical recovery as a result of consistent music therapy sessions.



What is Music Therapy?

Music Therapy is the practice of using music interventions to achieve individualized goals. This can involve singing, composing or listening to music.

Especially for individuals with dementia or Alzheimer's disease, personalized playlists composed of classics from their youth can trigger memory recall, foster communication, and enhance emotional responses, even in individuals who normally don't express themselves as well.

The Benefits of Music for Senior Adults

COGNITIVE & EMOTIONAL WELLNESS THROUGH SOUND



Cognitive Benefits

- Slows cognitive decline
- Enhances memory
- Stimulates mental activity

Emotional Upliftment

- Reduces stress and anxiety
- Boosts mood
- Provides an emotional outlet



Social Connection

- Group music activities
- Combats loneliness
- Fosters intergenerational bonds

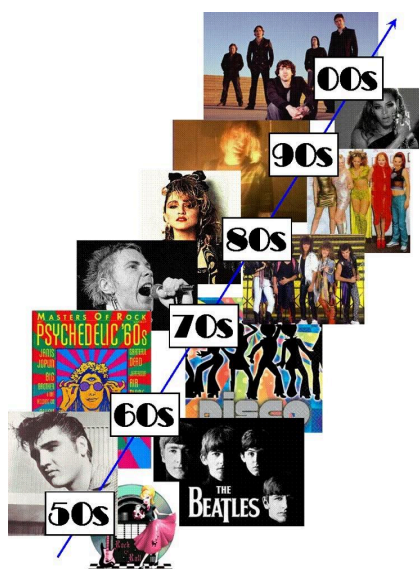
Physical Health

- Encourages movement
- Supports motor skills
- Manages pain



CONNECTING WITH THE RESIDENTS THROUGH MUSIC

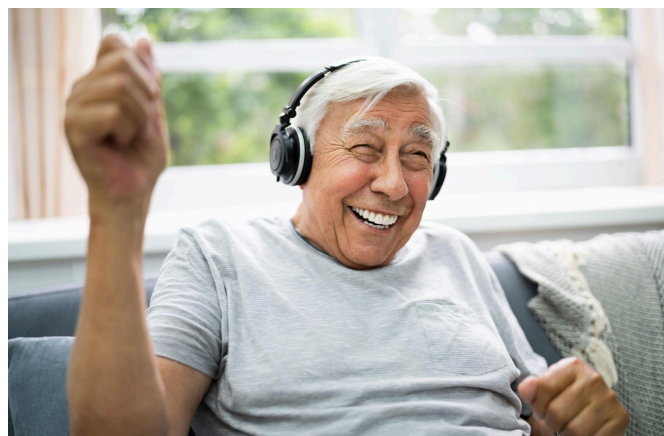
Many seniors hold strong emotional connections to the music they listened to when they were growing up, so playing songs that are familiar to them can reawaken dormant memories, spark meaningful conversations, and elicit joy in their day. By going out of the way to learn about and remember residents' musical preferences, as well as encouraging them to share their own experiences with such music, volunteers hold the key to creating meaningful interactions with the residents and making them feel valued and heard.



Start by asking residents what kinds of music they enjoy listening to. Some may prefer specific genres such as jazz, country, gospel, or classical music, while others may have favorite artists or songs they love. If the residents are unsure of what they like to hear or simply have no musical preference, try using familiar songs from the 1950s through the 1980s as conversation starters, which tend to resonate the most with the majority of seniors.

Source: <https://www.pinterest.com/pin/what-decade-has-produced-the-best-music-557320522637202672/>

Ask the residents about a concert they have gone to in the past and how that experience made them feel. You can also ask residents if there is a musician or concert they wish they had seen in person, which can lead to fun conversations about their favorite bands and lasting experiences.



Source: <https://leweslodge.com/benefits-of-music-therapy-for-seniors/>

Through simple questions and shared listening experiences, music can become a meaningful way to build connection, stimulate memory, and foster enjoyable conversations with the residents.

GROUP MUSIC AND TEAM BUILDING (Pg 4)

One of the most beautiful and powerful components of music is its ability to be shared and to cultivate joyful emotions and memories for groups of people. Additionally, while solo music performance is extremely impactful, when music is played by multiple people, said impact can be amplified through stronger connections. Incorporating residents suffering from various cognitive decline into the music also strengthens the impact.



When two or more volunteers play instruments or sing, collaborating can make the music experience more engaging for residents. Even simple harmonies or call-and-response patterns can create a sense of participation and shared joy, while boosting confidence for both volunteers and residents. If possible, playing music outside with the residents can also boost mood and generate positive connections with sound and nature.

Group music events do not always require live music either! Karaoke nights and group playlists are a simple and fun way to involve residents and foster a team like connection. Volunteers can coordinate with staff at each site to ensure smooth transitions, favorite song selections, and inclusive participation. Musical games like bingo or trivia add an extra layer of excitement, encouraging residents to listen, remember, and celebrate together.



Incorporating movement and rhythm into the music can boost engagement. Activities like “Just Dance” sessions or drum circles allow residents to translate music to bodily expression, ultimately promoting teamwork, cognitive stimulation, and great shared joy. Moreover, a little light exercise or movement of the hands is always a beneficial outcome.

ONE-ON-ONE MUSIC ENGAGEMENT

Spending time one-on-one with older adults living with Alzheimer's or dementia can be very meaningful. It brings a sense of familiarity, trust, and a chance to learn more about their life's story. Music is a powerful way to connect even when words are hard to find. Music is a universally enjoyable experience that can unite people from all backgrounds and cultures. It all starts with creating a connection. Maybe start by playing a familiar song or humming a tune, and watch how the resident responds. If you notice them smile, tap their foot, or begin to sing, follow their lead and encourage them. If they seem unsure, be patient, slow down, and try a different song. Gently say things like, "Would you like to clap with me," or "You can join in however you'd like" to offer a space of creative engagement.



Song choice is very important in ensuring a comfortable space is created for residents. Rather than loud or overwhelming sounds, choose soothing music and rhythms that are meaningful to them. The goal is not to be a musician, but to have fun with residents and encourage their participation. A great way of doing so is offering them the opportunity to create music with you. Offer simple instruments like maracas, bongos, and tambourines, and invite them to clap and play along to the beat. We want to celebrate even the small moments to make residents feel excited and seen.

In many ways, music is more than entertainment, but can meaningfully make all the difference in residents' mental and emotional well-being. These moments can foster connection and belonging through shared musical experiences and undivided interaction.



Even after the visit ends, the impact of music can continue. Residents may carry the feeling of the song with them, gently hum a tune, or find small moments of joy throughout their day.

FUTURE IDEAS

Beyond incorporating music into creative engagement sessions, volunteers are also encouraged to bring any suggestions for music initiatives to the HAND executive team. Having tangible goalposts can turn new ideas into sustainable programming, ensuring that music and sound-based engagement becomes a consistent, intentional part of residents' experiences.



For example, volunteers might want to offer a group music event and provide percussion instruments to residents. They might think to build a long-term instrument closet so that future volunteers can run similar sessions without starting from scratch. But moving from an idea to a durable program or resource requires coordination across several parts of HAND. Volunteers should

articulate the purpose of the suggested initiative and work with the executive team to ensure that the project aligns with HAND's broader goals. The executive team can then help coordinate fundraising and direct volunteers towards campus groups or partner organizations that can offer donations.

Page 1: Importance of Music for Cognitive Health (Brendan)

- Musical interventions have been shown to improve mood and encourage self-expression, even after neurodegenerative disorders have progressed

Possible images: Stock photo of seniors listening to music together or diagram of brain regions for memory

Page 2: Connecting w/ Residents thru music (JP)

- Connect with your audience through songs they might be more familiar with
- Ask them what kinds of songs they enjoy listening to
- Ready list of songs from 50s, 60s, 70s, 80s, classics if residents do not have past preferences
- Ask them about a fun concert they've gone to in the past and how that made them feel
- could also ask them about a concert they wish they could have seen in person that they never had a chance to

Possible images: Timeline of music decades w/ musical icons

Page 3: One-on-one music engagement

- Ways to incorporate music into your volunteering
 - i. One-on-one interactions
- Encourage residents to participate in creating music (singing, tambourines, boomwhackers, piano, bongos, maracas, etc.)
- Encourage the residents to feel free to join in and clap or sing along

Possible images: illustrations of instruments

Page 4: Group Music (Evelyn)

- i. Group events
 - If two or more volunteers play instruments or sing, consider collaboration with each other on the songs
 - Karaoke nights/group playlists, hep volunteers at each site to coordinate with employees
 - Musical bingo, trivia
 - Incorporated with movement-based activities, choreography, just dance
 - Drum circle

Possible images: Seniors singing/actively engaging in a circle

Page 5: Future ideas

III. Specific initiatives and suggestions

--> fundraiser in the spring to build an “instrument closet?”

Possible images: idk